

China 1950–1966: Not So Public Opinion Surveys

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In the context of government responses to challenges confronting existing political and economic arrangements, the founder of Princeton University's Office of Public Opinion Research, Hadley Cantril, observed in 1965 that "Information about what people want and will accept is vital if new institutions are to be devised to meet new needs and new conditions."¹ Prior to WWII, many governments had already drawn the same conclusion, and by the time he made it, Cantril's observation was no longer controversial.² In Great Britain, the Institute of Public Opinion, founded in 1937, had regarded the perfection of opinion survey methods as groundwork for modern superior government policy.³ In the Republic of China, President Chiang Kai-shek's domestic opposition had by 1939 elevated the need to "collect information on... the state of public opinion" to a major strategic concern.⁴ During the war, Britain's Ministry of Information regularly sought to advise the government by providing officialdom with survey reports on opinions on the home front, while the U.S. State Department encouraged systematic study and analysis of public opinion.⁵ Post-war, governments worldwide eagerly exploited what was still occasionally spoken of as the "young art" of opinion surveys to develop "adequate and sound information on what the public thinks."⁶

The gauging of opinion was guided by a shared assumption that the outcome of well-designed "scientific" surveys could capture and metaphorically mirror the hearts and minds of the general public.⁷ Modern public opinion measurement was regarded by its adherents as a "flexible and potentially most reliable" adjunct of democracy.⁸ "The ballot box has always been a central institution in our system of government," the president of the American Association for Public Opinion Research noted in a *Political Science Quarterly* article in 1946, "but it is inefficient in that a single vote taken infrequently is allowed to decide too much."⁹ In China, patriotic

progressives needing to overcome conservatives' lingering doubts about public opinion surveys could argue their case by citing leadership coaches of antiquity who like Mencius (390–305 b.c.) had maintained that states flourished when their rulers "got at the hearts of the people" and became able "to collect for them what they like, and not to lay on them what they dislike."¹⁰

As adopted, modern opinion survey routines were fundamentally similar. Best practice from the outset demanded of the men and women gathering data that they "take into account only what the respondent himself said, accepting it at face value, and not reading anything into it by way of inferences."¹¹ During training, they were told that "in order to ensure that the information remains truthful, the facts or statements seen or heard must be recorded in their original form, and no subjective opinions in terms of 'I maintain that...' or 'My feeling is that...' may be added to them."¹² But procedural differences – some subtle, others less so – did invariably develop. Alternative approaches to the all-important metonymical ("part for whole") question of representativeness were tested and assessed, further refined when deemed superior and quietly abandoned when recognized as inferior. Social science concluded that "people tend to react to propaganda and to events in terms of thought patterns peculiar to their occupation, economic status, and environment," and in the United States, surveys of public opinion sought to increase representative accuracy by way of sampling that discriminated between classes (e.g. "upper," "upper middle," "middle," "lower middle," "lower," and "working") and occupational categories (e.g. "professional; business," "white collar," "skilled," "unskilled," and "non-labor").¹³ Elsewhere, discriminating sampling also took socioeconomic class, stratification, proportionate representation, age, sex, and so on into account. But where the survey setting bore only scant resemblance to the American one, the

conceptions employed and the labels applied could – and often had to, if findings were to prove meaningful – be quite different.

Internationally, the precise *form* that findings were given also differed to some extent due to diverging preferences among customers in government. The favorite, no doubt, was a product that foregrounded measurement and quantification. But numbers, stripped of context, gave away only so much about people’s opinions: what an *n*-percent decline or growth in the number of those who espoused a particular view really meant remained uncertain. Even where rigor in all methodological respects could be taken for granted, it was still the case, as one political science textbook eventually spelled out, that “undue emphasis on quantification might lead to an exaggerated reliance on some types of indicators, because they were quantified, and to the neglect of other aspects, such as *cultural factors*, not as easily amenable to mathematical treatment.”¹⁴ Under the circumstances, when it came to the mirroring of the public mind, some countries’ opinion survey customers sensitized by personal experience to the weight of “cultural factors” preferred findings presented to them in a richer, anecdotal format.

On top of everything else, there were ever-present differences motivated by an interest in controlling *access* to survey products. In what customers in government justified as legitimate efforts not to pollute the public information environment by creating – rather than gauging – opinion, survey findings that turned out to “raise questions” did not always see the light of day, but only came to be shared with a restricted audience and not with the public at large or competing political forces.¹⁵ Early on, social scientists were drawing attention to the delicate “propaganda implications” of opinion survey products and “their role in a democratic society.”¹⁶

Work on a global history of the modern political public opinion survey has long been hampered by a scarcity of information on how it was conducted in some of the world’s most populous countries. Without understanding “the rest” and incorporating its national and local histories, what is generalized often merely chronicles the unfolding of events in “the West.” This paper is but a modest attempt at remedying part of this bias by tracing some defining elements of survey praxis in China during the first two decades of the Cold War.

“Social intelligence”: similar scope, dissimilar procedure

When it founded the People’s Republic of China (PRC) in 1949, after a four-year long civil war, the Chinese Communist Party (CCP) subsumed surveys of public opinion under what it called the acquisition of “social intelligence” (*sheqing*).¹⁷ At the time, social intelligence was an umbrella term employed by the party’s public security officers – many of whom were recently demobilized People’s Liberation Army (PLA) officers and men – as synonymous with documenting “reactions on the part of various social strata to party and government policies and laws” as well as, in addition, “the spread of reactionary rumors, slogans, leaflets, and facts surrounding counterrevolutionary sabotage” and “trends in organized religion, secret societies, reactionary political parties and organizations, among *tewu*, landlords and rich peasants, thieves and bandits, former Chiang Kai-shek officers...”¹⁸ It was not unusual for products of social intelligence understood in this way to be viewed critically by government customers as “spoiled by a tendency to simply record everything that is picked up, rather than actively follow the major changes taking place in society and then consciously – and with some focus – collect information of relevance.”¹⁹

With the CCP now in government, social intelligence ceased to refer to vacuum cleaner information gathering, and the term as such, carried over, was given a narrower doctrinal definition. Directives from Beijing asked public security officers nationwide to refrain from documenting local banditry, robbery, instances of sabotage, etc. under the social intelligence rubric.²⁰ Primers with names like *How to Gather Social Intelligence* (1950) and *Social Intelligence Investigation* (1952) explained to them that social intelligence as an activity was henceforth to be focused on documenting public opinion and opinion trends.²¹ As summarized in doctrine, it was first of all to “record the reactions of local figures representative of various [social] strata and sectors... to each major party and government policy and measure.” Secondly, as a prerequisite for institutional self-regulation of the kind advocated by Mao Zedong as “from the masses, to the masses,” it was to monitor opinion that had a direct bearing on the so-called “central work” (*zhongxin gongzuo*) of the surveying institution itself. (The central work assigned by the government to the public security organs, for

example, was to detect, prevent, and protect against threats to the operation of a people's democratic dictatorship.) Lastly, social intelligence was to document opinions, as expressed by members of the public, on sudden or unexpected "major domestic and international events."²²

That official government representatives themselves directly impacted the Chinese information environment and were unable to function as neutral recorders of public opinion was well understood. In that respect, the situation in the PRC differed little from what it had been in the Republic of China and earlier. When the Guomindang-controlled Bureau of Social Affairs of the Government of Greater Shanghai conducted a survey of the city's average working families in 1929–1930, its investigators ran up against widespread unwillingness to "render the necessary information" and reluctance to "disclose certain facts."²³ In the twilight years of the Qing empire (1644–1911), Mandarins attempting to conduct China's first modern census had encountered widespread suspicion and grassroots resistance characterized by one historian a century later as "protests against the hegemonic order of modernity."²⁴ In many quarters in the early PRC, ordinary citizens hesitated to speak frankly when invited by an inquisitive officialdom to answer questions or share opinions. Public security officers approaching "bourgeois democratic personages and representative individuals," for example, were frustrated by the difficulty involved in ascertaining what the head of the CCP Central Social Affairs Department, the predecessor of the new national Ministry of Public Security, spoke of as "their true attitudes, unlike the words of praise and support they express for us."²⁵ Needless to say, the setting could hardly have been more different, but the hurdle confronted in direct interviewing in China resembled what contemporaneous pollsters in the United States also faced when (in the words of one of them) ordinary Americans "in the lower social strata" refused to answer questions faithfully because they were "actually frightened; frightened of authorities in general, of the FBI in some places, and of the Communists in others (as we found last summer [in 1948] in rural Vermont)."²⁶

The CCP knew that data did not exist independently of the measuring procedure used and also that the *manner* in which one obtained the data had a way of determining the results. The requirements of genre invariably molded the expression of the

message, and what could be elicited by way of direct querying was rarely what sharp-witted public security officers recognized as a truthful representation of opinion actually held. Much of the time, interviews did little more than invite confirmation of the existing ideology. To meaningfully mirror Chinese public opinion, a survey had to proceed from a grasp of the *entire* social, political, and interpersonal situation in which opinion was expressed, captured, and recorded.²⁷

The CCP's efforts to devise a survey procedure that mitigated misrepresentation to officialdom of "true attitudes" led to the adoption of a tactic of information collection natural to former military men used to interacting with members of the public who knew what they thought but were unwilling, or afraid, to reveal it when asked up-front. As elaborated upon in *How to Gather Social Intelligence*, in order to arrive at an accurate reading of opinion, the best tactic was the least intrusive one of "relying largely on listening and observing to understand matters" and only when called for "approaching people for information, but not necessarily asking them head-on, since a direct question very often fails to elicit a truthful answer."²⁸ The tactic as such had no uniquely "communist" characteristics: in the spring of 1944, Hadley Cantril had indoctrinated field agents of the Office of Strategic Services (OSS) (the WWII predecessor of the Central Intelligence Agency) in its use to survey German public opinion (to obtain "brief and specific information" behind enemy lines) on clearly defined subjects. Cantril's agents were, in his own words, given "suggestions for indirect conversational approaches... likely to elicit the type of information we wanted" and had it impressed upon them that "all information be obtained through casual conversation to avoid any suspicion on the part of those interviewed."²⁹ In 1949, University of Wisconsin sociologist Howard Becker, who like Cantril had a WWII background in the OSS, argued that the use of a survey tactic that muffled the mechanics of data collection altogether (what he called "black polling") might even in some circumstances be useful for entirely legitimate peacetime purposes in the United States.³⁰

This quasi-clandestine way of collecting data – expounded as "oblique," rather than "head-on," in the new Beijing Public Security School where a first class of cadets graduated in January 1950 – was barely distinguishable from suspicionless

surveillance of the individual, yet differed ultimately in that customers of social intelligence were interested in aggregated *masses* of individuals, rather than in citizen Zhang or citizen Li.³¹ What concerned Chinese civilian government and military policy makers, party secretaries, ministers, mayors and provincial governors, was what an adequate tally of statements emanating with different social strata revealed about the opinion of the public *in general*. If and when the relevant record of an individual's opinion was anonymized (as sometimes happened, sometimes didn't) it mattered little, as long as the metadata attached to the record still allowed for the opinion's ascription to a person from background A expressing it in setting B around the time of C. That this was so can be gleaned from early survey products, as well as from advice given rookie public security officers like the one whose informant documented opinions on a university campus in the city of Harbin. It was excellent, the young officer was told by his operational line superiors, that his informant was "giving us a record in writing" of stated "reactions" by members of the intelligentsia to major international events. But he was also to tell the informant that "in the future, he need not spell out any personal *names* [of individuals being cited] but may instead simply write XXXX."³²

Organization: public security bureaus and fusion centers

In organizational terms, the early PRC never saw the concentration of opinion survey work in a single government or CCP entity. To record the views of people in general on current major issues was a mission given public security bureaus nationwide. In the winter of 1951, as itemized in a list of requirements drawn up in Beijing, those issues ranged from the war on the Korean peninsula and the CCP's "suppression of counter-revolutionaries" campaign to the state of the economy, disaster relief, state building, land reform, religious life and activities, and "major domestic and international events."³³

While public security bureaus as government institutions were *primus inter pares*, CCP United Front departments shared with them the more narrow task of sampling opinion percolating within China's non-communist political parties and among un-affiliated so-called "bourgeois democratic personages." To develop a broader picture of popular reactions and attitudes to government economic policies and arrangements was a responsibility divided between the

public security sector and government fiscal, financial, business, trade, and macro-level planning departments. And to document opinion voiced by resident foreigners was a task shared by public security bureaus and the Foreign Affairs Divisions of local governments.³⁴ *How* the entities involved went about "listening and observing" differed, not the least because only the public security sector was authorized by the CCP to use altogether clandestine survey instruments. Whereas much of the raw data from other entities came in the form of replies to more or less transparent querying, it was the testimony collected "obliquely" by the informants of public security bureaus that retained all the characteristic imperfections and contradictions of authentic opinion revealed in spontaneous human language.³⁵

Worth noting is that while CCP policy makers – who after all aspired to devise and find acceptance for new institutions that had nothing less than a revolutionary near-total transformation of society as their common denominator – regarded social intelligence as indispensable, the leaderships of the entities meant to provide it struggled from the outset to incentivize its production. As the Shaanxi provincial Public Security Bureau observed in 1952, its own central work had to give precedence to collecting and rewarding information with a nexus to *threats*. That stance meant that "we must neglect other tasks" and, as a result, the bureau's surveys of public opinion in general were often far from "timely, our information carries little ideological weight, and its reference value to the Party Committee and to higher level intelligence organs is not great."³⁶ A full decade and a half later, similar sentiment still echoed in much of China's public security sector. As one municipal sub-division in Beijing admitted self-critically in 1966, its "officers in some units do just not pay any attention to [social] intelligence work" and fail to "get a sense of what is trending, among operational targets, and to collect reactions, good and bad."³⁷

As conducted nationwide by public security bureaus, survey work ended up logistically prioritizing urban communities and semi-rural and rural communities located in proximity of large and medium sized cities.³⁸ Unable to invest scarce full-time manpower in obtaining it, public security bureau leaderships delegated responsibility for identifying raw data, on which social intelligence products could be made to rest, to section chiefs in operational line divisions. As collection managers, these conveniently positioned

mid-level leading cadres (*zhongji lingdao ganbu*) already had to note everything their “eyes and ears” picked up. The assumption appears to have been that with little extra effort, they could therefore be relied upon to determine when a random statement in a field officer’s memo, remarks in an agent contact report, information from a key informant, and so on merited citing as illustrative of public opinion.

By the section chiefs, together with their handling instructions in the margins of otherwise unprocessed text, passages were identified and highlighted as containing opinion data of relevance and forwarded laterally to *ad hoc* social intelligence fusion centers for aggregation. Not actual nomenklatura units in their own right, merely concurrent missions assigned to a suitably qualified desk officer or two, these fusion centers were located either in a public security bureau’s General Office or attached to the operational line division charged with the maintenance of social order. In the latter case, why here? The answer seems to have been because that particular division routinely engaged with local police stations whose officers in turn interacted with the community on a day-to-day basis and therefore already, at any given time, would have been closer than most to “the word in the street.”

In Tianjin in 1950–1951, a small municipal public security bureau fusion center collated what it received from section chiefs in operational line divisions and city district branches to produce, in simple mimeographed form, at more or less regular weekly intervals, the serial *Tianjin Social Intelligence* as well as the less frequent *Tianjin Social Intelligence General Circular*. These products of a continuous, rather than intermittent, survey effort to proactively document shifts in opinion were addressed to the municipal director of public security, with copies going out to city district branches and divisions. Once their content had been perused and endorsed by the director, additional copies duly travelled up the government bureaucracy to customers in “relevant *superior* organs” that, in the case of Tianjin, included the municipal Party Committee, the Ministry of Public Security in Beijing, and the CCP Central Committee North China Bureau.³⁹

Words, not numbers

Preference on the part of Chinese social intelligence customers was for duly contextualized raw data. The work of dedicated fusion centers, as a

result, did *not* involve translation, by qualitative data coders, of the opinions expressed by members of the public into a form amenable to tabulation and the production of precise statistics. In Washington D.C., for example, unlike in Beijing, results of a survey of public opinion (this one on government policy toward China) could in 1950 be summed up in the following fashion:

Shortly after the publication of the White Paper on China [i.e. *United States Relations with China*, published by the U.S. State Department on 5 August 1949–Ed.], a survey showed that only 36 percent of those questioned had heard anything about that document. Those who said they had heard or read something about it were then asked: “What is your opinion of the way the [United States] government had handled the China situation?” Fifty-three percent disapproved, saying that it was “very poor,” “U.S. blundered,” or “U.S. should have given more help.” Twenty-six percent approved, saying that it was “very good” or that the “U.S. did best as it could.” One percent stated that the United States should help China, two percent that we should stay out, and 18 percent said that they did not know.⁴⁰

Recurrent American surveys containing similar amounts of statistical detail could easily be compared and, over time, provide numbers that appeared to document public opinion trends with impressive precision.

What is sometimes overlooked by students of history who perhaps, unlike the present author, do not themselves have the germane hands-on experience, is the degree to which qualitative data coding bestows powers of discrimination and determination on the humble coder creating manageable categories from spontaneous human language and imposing structure onto unstructured responses.⁴¹ What such powers over the content of the form entail may, in the American case, be gleaned from the instructions issued by the Office of Public Opinion Research in the 1950s: “When you start coding,” coders were told, “break up what the respondent has said in reply to a particular question into each separate thought, either by underlining or by slant marks. Then jot down on some scratch paper the code for each of these thoughts as you come to them.” When replies to queries on political fears and worries, hopes and

aspirations, were vague or confusing, coders were asked to determine what they “really” entailed and code them accordingly: “Sometimes a respondent may mix things up a bit and mention what is really a fear under that part of the question which asks about hopes, or vice versa. In such cases, code the remark for what it really is, even though it may appear under the wrong part of the question.” And when finite code categories did not include one that matched a stated opinion, coders were invited to discreetly assign to it an alternative near-match category to which it “obviously” fit: “[S]uppose a respondent expresses as one of his personal aspirations in answer to Question 1(A) that the present government should continue in power. There is no such category in the code for personal aspirations, but the remark obviously fits under the subject matter denominated ‘Political.’ It should therefore be coded 4-8 (‘Miscellaneous aspirations having to do with the political situation’).”⁴²

Whereas some may have welcomed a more precise quantification of public opinion, CCP social intelligence customers at the ultimate national level were more concerned with the loss of control that such coding of data, if attempted, would have relinquished to local officialdom. To the extent that it necessitated inference and subjective interpretation, qualitative data coding entailed precisely the kind of invasive information management that social intelligence primers instructed fusion centers to eschew. Therefore, the end product of a Chinese public opinion survey was for many years *not* a discussion similar to the American one of precise percentage figures, but – in something like a simple descending order from “most,” via “fairly” or “less,” to “least” common – a narration of stated opinions in context judged by collection managers to be broadly representative.

Findings: “Detailed, truthful, lively, and timely”

At the end of 1959, for example, urban public security bureaus in Beijing, Tianjin, Baoding, Ji’nan, Qingdao, Benxi, Shenyang, Changchun, and Lüda all surveyed public opinion on the nationwide amnesty of prisoners to commemorate the tenth anniversary of the founding of the PRC. Initial findings quickly appeared in the Ministry of Public Security’s Top Secret *Public Security Work Bulletin* under headlines such as “Stated Opinions of the Masses and of Bourgeois Elements in Ji’nan on First Batch of Amnestied

War Criminals” and “Stated Opinions of Various Strata in Beijing on First Batches of Amnestied War Criminals and De-Labelled Rightists.”⁴³ The findings were bereft of precise statistics, but the ministry General Office (home to the *Public Security Work Bulletin*’s editors and aggregators of lower-level data) maintained that “*on the whole*, the basic masses endorse the amnesty policy and widely praise the party’s policy as a wise one,” albeit that “*some* find it hard to accept and think they should not be released.” Opinions illustrating the survey results were then cited, like the following sample in one final paragraph meant to show that, in addition, an even less numerous “some” remained uncomfortable with the amnesty and as a result “quite anxious”:

The Lüda urban resident Li Yuzhen said “Those guys used to be big officials, and I now wonder have they really been successfully reformed? I’d say, not necessarily. One really has to continue to keep an eye on them.” Commune member Liang Shutian, from the Nanyuan Commune in Beijing, said: “Released this time around are all the big-shots and you wonder what they’ll be told to do? Government organs, that’s for sure, won’t be able to employ them. In my opinion, one should just give them something somewhere that’s enough for them to live on, and that’s it.” He Guangyu, employed by the Sichuan Provincial Museum, said: “What’s needed now that those guys have been set free is for somebody to monitor their behavior. Otherwise, they’ll go on doing damage.”⁴⁴

In the form of “soft data” like this, the write-up of survey findings involved knowledge representation far more reliant on narrativization than precise tabulation.

In January 1955, regulations issued by the Ministry of Public Security sought to standardize the forms and dissemination of intra-bureaucratic texts, and explained that as far as social intelligence products were concerned, they had to be “detailed, truthful, lively, and timely.”⁴⁵ In September 1955, Hu Qiaomu, style editor of the official *Selected Works of Mao Zedong*, gave the ministry feedback, telling it that Mao Zedong was specifically commending the quality of its restricted circulation texts.⁴⁶

To the Ministry of Public Security, *detailed* meant specific and exhaustive but readable. “In general,” Hu Qiaomu observed in an extended

elaboration on communication skills, of which a transcript was shared with public security officers, “reading tables is cumbersome by comparison, so when you write reports you want to opt for more words, less tables. Also, employ headings and intros, add background and make comparisons.”⁴⁷ *Truthful* meant accurately and credibly accounting for facts as known. As one reasoned, Hu Qiaomu stressed, the definitions of one’s terms must not be allowed to slide. To draw any conclusions from facts with accuracy, one’s concepts could not “mean one thing in one sentence and something different in the next.”⁴⁸ And *lively* sanctioned occasional reliance on quasi-dramaturgical forms of representation to create expectation and sustain the interest of readers. In the words of Hu Qiaomu: “Do not hesitate to give your exposition some thought: how to write in order to make people take an interest, continue reading, and understand...”⁴⁹ *Timely*, finally, included use of the telephone as a means of transmission of finished social intelligence products. In July 1960, in a set of recently up-dated regulations governing intra-bureaucratic communication, the Ministry of Public Security asked for major and particularly significant “opinions being expressed in different social strata concerning major domestic and international events” to be “reported as swiftly as possible over secure telephone lines.”⁵⁰

The unwitting source: authentic, but just how relevant?

Internationally, organizations relying on the use of questionnaires as their preferred opinion survey method discovered early on that when their grassroots investigators “know too much about the study, they may unconsciously guide the answers and counteract the value of the material obtained.”⁵¹ In the PRC, public security bureaus were particularly ill at ease with the possibility of witting informants on the ground prefiguring, with positive *or* negative intent, the corpus of raw data from which section chiefs and fusion centers hoped to develop sound social intelligence. Precautions taken as a result were never more extreme than in the years of regime consolidation, at the start of the 1950s, when officers handling informants confronted social strata known to remain largely hostile to the new government. Here they had to rely on members of the very same strata, but with mutual trust in short supply, details about what kind of data they sought and why could simply not be divulged.

To make use of the doctrinal term “social intelligence” when briefing informants (to spell out, in other words, *what* officers aspired to develop) was out of the question and for officers to “unnecessarily elaborate” on the precise *scope* of the data that interested them was also ruled out.⁵² Archival records from the Harbin Public Security Bureau illustrate how constraints like these impacted on efficacy and frustrated section chiefs struggling to “extract” (*zhaichu*) public opinion from what informants gave them.

In 1950, the city of Harbin had a resident population of 780,000 and was home to some ten thousand or so households whose heads were former members of reactionary political parties or organizations, the puppet [Manchukuo] police or paramilitary police, or adversary intelligence.⁵³ Gauging opinion in this “special demographic” (*teshu renkou*), as the households were designated in PRC census records, was a responsibility delegated by the municipal public security bureau to its subsidiary first division Investigation Section. The section drew extensively on informants from within the “special demographic.” One of them was Agent 107, an unemployed 28 year old typist in the Daowai city district.⁵⁴ In a note to the officer who served as her contact, she admitted within a few weeks of her recruitment in the early summer of 1950 (when the intention had originally been to use her as a covert asset in an investigation, quickly aborted, of behavior associated with pre-incident counter-revolutionary activity) to finding it “difficult to pick up information” and asked for positive guidance.⁵⁵ Very little of the latter was forthcoming, however. The Investigation Section was reluctant to give her precise instructions about what it hoped she would pick up, because the section chief feared she would, if witting, proceed to openly “probe” the opinions of people around her. And the moment she started to ask vaguely political questions head-on, those same people would become suspicious, clam up, or cease to frankly express their opinion in her presence.

The Investigation Section staff was in two minds about Agent 107. Her handler insisted she had the right “attitude” and favored monetizing her work, but the section chief objected, probably suspecting that it would just encourage her to make future reporting fit patterns of previous information favorably received in the hope of consolidating rewards. The section chief accepted that under the circumstances all he

could hope for was that every now and then, opinion of interest would be overheard and reported by her from within her undoubtedly target-rich environment. What she handed over in written form when debriefed read like pages from a diary – a first-person chronicle of her own daily movements. Most of the time, that chronicle was judged to be painfully unsystematic, but on those occasions when it did contain something relevant to the gauging of public opinion, the section chief would scribble a few words in the margin ordering the “desk officer handling documentation” to “extract the relevant social intelligence” and share it with the bureau fusion center.

The section chief’s evaluation of an eight-page report from Agent 107 on 18 April 1951 was: “This is what she reported this time around, and it consists mainly and primarily of social intelligence.”⁵⁶ On page four, he underlined the words “government’s suppression of counterrevolutionary elements” which would have been the issue on which opinion was to be “extracted” from the following passage:

At 11 a.m. on 10 April at Wang Hongchang’s residence at 138 Fushun Street Yang Guizhi said “the government’s suppression of counterrevolutionary elements gets more intense with each passing day. But *there are still reactionaries out there who don’t know their time is up, who exploit the Christian church to conduct sabotage*. Why, while none of us are really counterrevolutionary elements, it all leaves a taste hard to describe in here.”⁵⁷

On a different page in the same report, the section chief again scribbled “extract social intelligence” in the margin and underlined what the fusion center was to add to its running record of current opinion targeting “major domestic and international events,” here now represented by the war on the Korean peninsula:

After lunch on 11 April in his home at 28 Dalouding Street, when we talked about him still operating his push cart, Xu said “forget it, sooner or later the fighting is bound to start. See how the newspapers report a group of fifty to sixty American airplanes on a bombing mission in the skies over Andong? *Sooner or later we’ll see them in the skies over [illegible] as well*. For now all I’m doing is repeating what others are saying. *Anyone who spouts serious rubbish will be executed, that’s how serious things are*.”⁵⁸

A week earlier, the same issues and events had been dealt with in a survey of public opinion expressed in the PRC capital, and what members of the “special demographic” were overheard saying in Beijing was similar to what Agent 107 happened to pick up in Harbin.⁵⁹ What the surviving archival record does not reveal is whether marked-up snippets from her reporting in the end *did* appear in any aggregate social intelligence products documenting public opinion on the “suppression of counter-revolutionaries” campaign, the war on the Korean peninsula, etc.

Attempts to document anything more specific than general attitudes using unwitting informants proceeding “obliquely” must have been quite discouraging. In what Agent 107 reported from within Harbin’s “special demographic,” the ratio of pertinence to irrelevance was ridiculously low. Words rarely coalesced neatly into opinion, as they might in an imaginary interview (“Now, if you ask me, I would say that so-and-so really is...!”), in response to a questionnaire survey (“All of the above!”) or, for that matter, a police interrogation. The one positive thing her raw data had going for it was its undisputable authenticity: a record of private and public assertions by family and acquaintances, friends and enemies. As community interaction deeply embedded in her diary-like reporting, it defeated any attempt at qualitative data coding. For public security officers in the Investigation Section to break up what lay hidden in the transcript into separate “thoughts,” assign “obvious” categories to the latter, and finally code them on the basis of what they “really” entailed was simply impossible. But as flawed as early PRC social intelligence praxis may well have been, it did however allow for a reasonably adequate documentation of politically sensitive opinion. It solved the all-important problem of preference falsification, and during regime consolidation, that was what the CCP judged to be of overriding importance.

Influential opinion? People on other people

Once CCP regime consolidation gave way to socialist state building, a modified public security doctrine directed operational line divisions to rid themselves of underperforming informants, while retaining and training promising ones able to monitor “a particular sphere or an entire sector.”⁶⁰ Archival records from Harbin provide snap-shots of a self-confident social intelligence praxis that continued to rely

on the “oblique” tactic, but by mid-decade put its trust in a leaner source base of cooperating and, above all, *witting* informants.

One established sphere in which the PRC government took particular interest was organized religion, and here public security bureaus (and CCP United Front departments) routinely gauged the opinions of its “upper stratum” (*shangceng*). In Harbin, that stratum included the imams of the city’s mosques: prominent Chinese similar in kind to ones that Julian L. Woodward in 1946, in a discussion of opinion polling among United States population sub-groups, had called “so-called ‘thought leaders’” and sociologists by 1957 spoke of as “opinion leaders,” a term defined as “men who exert personal influence upon a certain number of other people in certain situations.”⁶¹ The Harbin public security bureau’s first division subsidiary National Minorities Section (a/k/a the Muslim Group) was by mid-decade running in their midst Agent 371, a teacher in his twenties and the nephew of a respected septuagenarian Muslim physician who operated a private clinic in the community.⁶² Initially, Agent 371 had assisted a predicated investigation of grain market manipulation, and when that investigation wound down, his excellent “upper stratum” access led division to retain and re-target him to register opinion trending among the imams and, by extension, in the city’s mosques.

Agent 371 was never left in doubt about what to pay attention to. The core building block of his reporting became the carefully contextualized (by whom, when, where, how, etc.) verbatim quote of opinion as stated. Every two weeks, when his pages of numbered paragraphs organized by subject or speaker, depending on the circumstances, reached the National Minorities Section, the section chief and his deputies would mark text that in their view merited forwarding to the bureau fusion center for “extraction” in social intelligence. Selection would be guided by the latest government information requirements and in 1956–1957, public opinion on commodity shortages and the quality of life was a domestic priority, while the once hot now cold war on the Korean peninsula had been superseded as an international priority by events unfolding in Eastern Europe and the Middle East.⁶³

In the first two months of 1957, Agent 371 presented altogether thirty-two different opinion quotes of varying length to his handler. Among these, section chiefs marked ten as “to be conveyed” to social

intelligence customers and as touching, specifically, on living conditions (*shenghuo*), on international events (*guoji*), and “on nuclear arms” (*dui yuanzi wuqi*). While ordinary Chinese might not have had much of an opinion on American attempts to roll back the Iron Curtain in Europe or the terminal decline of old British and French empires in the developing world, Harbin’s Muslim opinion leaders did. Theirs also happened to be remarkably well-informed opinion because, as Agent 371 had explained to his handler early on, “in order to stay on top of how the current situation is *truly* developing” they privately “listen in secret to the enemy’s radio broadcasts and regularly concern themselves with the international situation and current affairs.”⁶⁴

To the Harbin fusion center’s compilers of social intelligence, the attitudes and plentiful reflections, speculations, and comments on the world at large that Agent 371 documented were examples of vivid raw data that clearly merited sharing with the “relevant superior organs.” In the spring of 1959, the *Public Security Work Bulletin* in Beijing would draw on it to substantiate a ministerial claim that “some reactionary elements in religious circles” had “expressed jubilation” when they heard about recent unrest in Tibet. Bai Yusheng, the imam of the Harbin mosque, who featured prominently in what Agent 371 reported, was alleged to have concluded from party and government policy that

Inevitably, a boil full of pus will swell... And now this is what you get. You just can’t gobble things up at this rate. Here where we are, in China, the more things start to crack, the better. This incident with the Tibetans, isn’t it all because they... carry out their reforms far too aggressively? This wouldn’t have happened otherwise!⁶⁵

Here it deserves to be added that unlike international relations, inter-*faith* relations (e.g. between Islam and Tibetan Buddhism) was never a common theme or sub-theme in what Agent 371 quoted Harbin’s imams as reflecting or commenting on.

The opinions of the men with whom Agent 371 interacted and the statements he recorded typically concerned unfolding *events*, but at the same time tended to be highly *person*-centered, as in the examples below. On 21 March 1956, when much attention in Chinese educated circles remained focused on what had transpired politically at the Soviet Communist Party’s Twentieth Congress in the second half

of February, Agent 371 presented his handler with a record of what his physician uncle had remarked in conversation three days earlier:

He said "Soviet doctors are that skilled and still they did not manage to save [Polish President Boleslaw] Bierut? They could not even cure his pneumonia or cold, and so he had to die in Moscow? Why, in the past they weren't able to cure Stalin or that Czech leader either. This shows that their skill isn't really all that great." (Note: I said: "Yes, the funeral was on the 16th, a stormy day with heavy snowfall!") "And yet everybody was told to display the national flag. Such a big fuss over the death of a foreign communist party leader. Why, come the day when old Mao (*referring to our leader*) has died, we're all going to have to wear mourning." (Note: I said: "He is strong and in good health, so maybe we need not worry.") "Well, you should not say that. People who use their brains often develop acute brain symptoms."⁶⁶

Next to this passage, a deputy section chief who read all of the reporting submitted by Agent 371 wrote in red the words "trends/convey."

Very often, Harbin's Muslim opinion leaders' comments on events and politicians involved comparisons, be it between the present and the past or between the outside world and China. Sometimes the comparison was metaphorical, giving voice to the speaker's understanding of something in terms of something else. Most of the time it involved judgement or an appraisal: X reminded someone of, bore some resemblance to, would never happen in, was exactly like, or had nothing to do with Y. In the spontaneous speech from which the Harbin Public Security Bureau's fusion center struggled to develop social intelligence, comparison was as ubiquitous as the pre-set answers to multiple choice questions in the questionnaire surveys employed outside China. In the example below, from 15 June 1957, the uncle of Agent 371 compared attempts by the CCP Chairman to devise "new institutions" in the present with similar attempts by the leader of the Guomindang in the past:

He said "Some of the laws and things stipulated by Mao Zedong actually aren't bad. What happens, however, is that the people below do a bad job. In the past, the same thing happened to Chiang Kai-shek: the people

below had to make a total mess of some of the good things he stipulated. This time around, [in response to] the criticisms of the communist party, if they're able to change, it will really be great. But what I fear is that they won't change and that once things settle down again, nothing will in the end have been resolved and it will again all turn out the way it did for Chiang Kai-shek."⁶⁷

Next to this passage, a deputy section chief wrote "convey." As itemized in the most up-to-date list of information requirements circulating at the time, the passage fitted perfectly under public opinion on the communist party's rectification campaign and on Mao Zedong's advocacy of letting "a hundred flowers blossom and a hundred schools of thought contend."

Whenever a speaker's angle involved a comparison of the legitimacies of competing Chinese governments, section chiefs paid particular attention. In a report dated 28 December 1956, for example, Agent 371 documented opinion expressed in private "some-time between 8.10 – 9.00 a.m. on 23 December" on the supposed international standing of the PRC Premier Zhou Enlai. In the margin of the report, the section chief who read it wrote "to be conveyed" next to the following passage:

Don't be fooled by the friendly reception that Zhou Enlai gets during his foreign visits. It's only here with us, in China, that he enjoys fame and prestige. Worldwide, he has no fame and prestige. Now, T. F. Tsiang, the Taiwan representative at the United Nations: he's somebody with real fame and prestige. The people at the United Nations all have esteem for him, they all address him "Doctor Tsiang." If he wasn't up to it, would they address him Doctor Tsiang?⁶⁸

Zhou Enlai was, in 1956–1957, the PRC politician of importance on whom members of Harbin's Muslim elite were most likely to comment. Even quite trivial speculation about what he was believed to be thinking, known to have said, or understood to be doing, appeared in social intelligence. So for example on 31 January 1957, Agent 371 wrote that during a recent hour-long conversation on international affairs, his uncle had said that "Zhou Enlai doesn't even get out of bed unless there's something to be gained from it. Unless it somehow benefits [China], he certainly will not pay a visit to another country."⁶⁹

And on 5 May 1957, in a report that he gave the title “Stated opinions picked up concerning President Voroshilov’s visit to China,” Agent 371 quoted Bai Yusheng as recently observing that “it says in the papers that when the [Soviet head of state’s] visit to China is over, he will also pay a visit to other countries. It’s what Zhou Enlai does as well, it’s a foreign relations exercise, to call on a number of countries with the aim of expanding one’s own camp.”⁷⁰

An intelligentsia gone silent

After the CCP had been in power for a decade, its overall reading of Chinese public opinion was that it was safe to assume that efforts to transform existing political and economic arrangements did enjoy considerable public support. Among concerned customers of social intelligence, however, disagreement had begun to surface over how to understand the implications of expressly negative opinion. From recent meta-data (e.g. age bracket, education, socioeconomic class) on who was voicing it, some concluded that fiercely critical attitudes could no longer be gauged as mere residue opinion mirroring minds shaped in the “old society” before 1949 and therefore certain to disappear within another generation. On the contrary, they argued, it was a harbinger of something new and potentially threatening that called for a proactive policy response. That was the view articulated by a number of intellectuals, economists and legal scholars at a closed conference called in July 1963 (six months after the publication in Chinese of *The New Class* by Milovan Djilas) to debate the emergence of a “new bourgeoisie” in the PRC during the socialist transition.⁷¹ In 1964, one alarmed theoretician writing in a classified East China CCP journal warned of the danger posed by naively regarding negative opinion in the PRC as but another “contradiction among the people” and by not responding proactively to the emergence of “new bourgeois elements” poised to undermine in-depth socialist capacity building.⁷²

Of particular concern to the CCP leadership at the time were members of China’s intelligentsia, the roughly five million educated men and women who represented culture, science, healthcare, media, education, etc. Since the early 1950s, so-called cultural protection divisions of urban public security bureaus had systematically developed social intelligence on them.⁷³ By 1955, the work of the divisions had laid the groundwork for a government sponsored attack

in the media on members of the intelligentsia who claimed that public opinion in the PRC was either non-existent or, if not, simply manufactured and therefore fundamentally false.⁷⁴ In 1957, social intelligence on trending opinion had undergirded a nation-wide crack-down on members of the intelligentsia seen as showing an averse “attitude” and whose co-operation with the CCP-led government was, in the words of Mao Zedong, “only in appearance and not in essence.”⁷⁵ After clampdowns like these, the raw data gathered using established tactics found less and less evidence of attempts at what Mao in 1962 called “to create public opinion” challenging CCP rule.⁷⁶

Efforts to survey actual opinion among the intelligentsia in the early 1960s are documented in the records of cultural protection divisions like the one in Harbin, code-named the Fifth Division. In the most prestigious of the city’s high schools, its informants included Agent 151, a teacher in his mid-forties with a pre-1949 background in Guomindang military intelligence and journalism.⁷⁷ In one of the city’s smaller colleges, the Fifth Division ran Agent 594, a teacher in his twenties who in his own words aspired to “take the thoughts of Chairman Mao as my guide in all my actions.”⁷⁸ And on one centrally located university campus, the division was able *inter alia* to draw on Agent 502, a former major in the Nationalist Army employed in the university administration.⁷⁹ While their immediate target communities differed (the issue of “representativeness” was not one for individual informants to consider but one dealt with in fusion centers), their missions came to overlap in the search for a bourgeoisie of the mind and “mirrored” evidence that verbalized the aspirations of a new class in the making.

As Fifth Division section chiefs repeatedly emphasized, and Agent 594 was told by his handler, “We absolutely have to seek truth from facts and be objective in how we understand facts and deal with people.”⁸⁰ Agent 502 was explicitly reminded to note both ideologically positive as well as negative stated opinions. In actuality, however, it was clear that under pressure from the CCP Centre, what section chiefs really craved were examples of dissent. A report he received in August 1963 led one section chief to express disappointment in Agent 502 and ask his recently assigned new handler to have him “focus on collecting what people say behind other people’s backs... and in particular on the statements and

actions of people who 'hold an opinion, in their minds, but dare not speak openly about it'."⁸¹ A month later, again disappointed, the section chief wrote to the handler: "Now as in the past, the matters reported by this agent are all positive things. How come he never picks up anything negative? Do we need to give some thought to his scope of activity and how he goes about things?"⁸²

Eager to document examples of expressly negative opinion on government and communist party policies and practices, some agents toyed with the idea of creatively modifying their elicitation tactics. On this point, public security officers were particularly weary of a tactic tested, but ultimately rejected by the Ministry of Public Security, in the early 1950s. It attempted to get people in one's immediate environment to speak with more open hostility about socialism in general by pretending oneself in conversation to hold more dissident views than one "really" did. Use of this create and capture tactic had been expressly banned when it was found to seriously pollute the domestic information environment by creating politically damaging opinion (i.e. "rumors") that reinforced the "arrogance of counter-revolutionary elements."⁸³ In 1964, Harbin's Fifth Division had to tell both Agent 151 and Agent 594 to refrain from attempting to use it.

A superficially similar tactic was however judged by the Fifth Division to be entirely legitimate, namely the stratagem of provoking debate by drawing attention to some particularly interesting item in the official news media. It relied primarily but not exclusively on *Reference News*, a restricted circulation daily published by the CCP's Xinhua News Agency. As Mao Zedong put it in 1964, "we have this paper called *Reference News* that university students and government cadres can all read, in which we publish all the important news released by the world's four great news agencies and Japan's Kyodo and Tass."⁸⁴ The editorial direction of the paper was not to translate and publish anything outrageously provocative or vile, but even so, on its pages China's intelligentsia were able to read much negatively slanted foreign news likely to trigger controversy.⁸⁵

In 1962, a section chief in the Fifth Division had suggested Agent 151 draw attention "to some particularly controversial item published in *Reference News* to engage [his target] in a conversation on current affairs to probe one step further what his opinions are and to see his attitude."⁸⁶ In 1965, Agent 502

was asked by his handler to employ the same stratagem in the hope of getting at what the people with whom he interacted were saying about recent major events reported in *Reference News*. "I pointed out to the agent," his handler explained to his own superiors, "that at this present stage of preparations for war, surely there will be some people who are of this or that opinion or who are making plans of some kind? This being the case, you cannot limit yourself merely to picking up and reporting people's positive remarks in public!"⁸⁷ But if section chiefs expected what they might be able to quote and include in social intelligence to be controversial, they must have been disappointed. The metaphorical mirror of the hearts and minds of Harbin's intelligentsia remained blank. In a long Contact Report on 5 November 1965, his handler noted that according to Agent 502, people were simply not voicing any personal *opinion*, but merely repeated "stuff that they read in our newspapers or in *Reference News*."⁸⁸

Conclusion

In 1949, the CCP's approach to grasping and interpreting public opinion had proven to be a hard currency of civil war victory. But after the founding of the PRC, social intelligence as developed for the government gradually ceased to serve as a reliable public opinion "mirror." Mao Zedong, for one, was among the first of its customers to conclude that his own private methods of estimating public reactions to CCP policies and government measures were superior.

The "oblique" tactic in which Chinese public security officers trusted suffered from flaws markedly different from, but no less numerous than, those that afflicted much public opinion survey work in the rest of the world at the time. In one 1952 instruction manual, social intelligence praxis that drew on the tactic was optimistically touted as a superior alternative to the "so-called 'public opinion' surveys and 'public opinion polls' [*minyī ceyān*] conducted in capitalist states."⁸⁹ But in practice, as opposed to theory, it was simply not delivering as promised. One handler's assessment on Christmas Eve 1965 of Harbin's Agent 502 read in retrospect like a metonymical judgement passed on fifteen years of non-intrusive "oblique" data acquisition *in its entirety*:

Fifteen years have passed since we recruited and started operating the agent, yet what we're getting out of him is basically just some

positive stuff that comes out of meetings etc. He shares with us only very little negative stuff and information on what’s being said behind people’s backs, even though I have on numerous occasions asked him to pay particular attention to such things in his work.... We need to think about whether or not he is still of any use to us.”⁹⁰

This handler’s superiors too, were clearly thinking about “whether or not” the existing social intelligence order was “still of any use to us.”

Across much of urban China, with ministerial authorization, the number of agents whose roles remained solely that of informants had by the mid-1960s already come down, in some provinces to less than ten percent of what it had been a decade earlier. In Harbin, Agent 151 was retired in 1964 and so too was Agent 502 in early 1966.⁹¹ In the late spring of 1966, the younger Agent 594 was briefly instructed by his handler to “focus on garnering responses to the Great Cultural Revolution,” and concentrate “especially... [on what is said] about the movement in private.”⁹² But at the end of the summer, when campus violence and tumult made his documentation of public opinion too dangerous, he too was de-activated and division ordered his handler to “henceforth *refrain from* tasking Agent 594 with gathering information on the unfolding movement.”⁹³

By November 1966, public security officers in Beijing acknowledged in the context of public opinion on even something as seemingly unproblematic as China’s launch of a medium-range ballistic missile carrying a nuclear warhead (duly publicized with fanfare “in our newspapers” on 28 October 1966) that a “majority of our operational targets as well as

some problematic individuals are not talking, act overcautiously, and do not lightly show their attitude, much less dare to publicly make reactionary or dissatisfied remarks.”⁹⁴ By the end of the year, the CCP’s social intelligence system, or what survived of it, faced *de facto* collapse. Some of its customers probably felt that a dysfunctional system was still better than none at all, but policy makers aligned with Mao’s thinking appear to have believed that to draw on the reporting it provided posed a “revisionist” political danger because of the false assurances it provided.

Meanwhile, Mao Zedong had already endorsed the spontaneous creation of an altogether new medium to serve as a mirror on the opinion of the general public in his Great Proletarian Cultural Revolution. Red Guard tabloids (“great things,” according to Mao) and, in particular, so-called “current information” (*dongtai*) newsletters produced and distributed by non-governmental organizations, briefly held out the promise of a “great proletarian information revolution.”⁹⁵ But after no more than another year, by the end of 1967, that experiment with a new paradigm of knowledge production had run its course. First to be officially banned were the information networks and newsletters, followed in 1968 by the enforced dissolution of the organizations that had managed them. Like the praxis that had preceded it, Mao’s all too-radical alternative means of getting information about “what people want and will accept to meet new needs and new conditions” was history.

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¹ Hadley Cantril, *The Pattern of Human Concerns* (New Brunswick NJ: Rutgers University Press, 1965), p. 3.

² Jean M. Converse, *Survey Research in the United States: Roots and Emergence, 1890–1960* (New Brunswick NJ: Transaction Publishers, 2009), p. 162.

³ Mark Roodhouse, “‘Fish-and-Chip Intelligence’: Henry Durant and the British Institute of Public Opinion, 1936–1963,” *Twentieth Century British History*, Vol. 24, No. 2 (2013), p. 225.

⁴ “Oppose Capitulationist Activity” (30 June 1939), in *Selected Works of Mao Tse-tung* (Beijing: Foreign Languages Press, 1965), Vol. 2, pp. 251–252.

⁵ Michael Balfour, *Propaganda in War 1939–1945: Organisations, Policies and Publics in Britain and Germany* (London: Routledge & Kegan Paul, 1979), pp. 71–75; Jeremy Brown and Robert M. Eisinger, "Polling as a Means Toward Presidential Autonomy: Emil Hurja, Hadley Cantril and the Roosevelt Administration," *International Journal of Public Opinion Research*, Vol. 10, No. 3 (Fall 1998), p. 10.

⁶ Julian L. Woodward, "Public Opinion Polls as an Aid to Democracy," *Political Science Quarterly*, Vol. 61, No. 2 (June 1946), p. 238–246.

⁷ David Riesman and Nathan Glazer, "The Meaning of Opinion," *The Public Opinion Quarterly*, Vol. 12, No. 4 (Winter 1948–1949), p. 634; "Polls, Propaganda, and Democracy," *Propaganda Analysis*, Vol. 4, No. 1 (November 1940), p. 6.

⁸ Woodward, "Public Opinion Polls," p. 246.

⁹ Ibid.

¹⁰ *The Works of Mencius*, Book IV, Part 1, Chapter IX, Paragraph 1.

¹¹ Cantril, *The Pattern*, p. 341.

¹² "Ruhe shouji sheqing" (How to Gather Social Intelligence), *Xi'nan gongan tongxun* (Southwest Public Security Newsletter), No. 2, 15 June 1950, p. 30.

¹³ "Polls, Propaganda, and Democracy," p. 2; Cantril, *The Pattern*, p. 375.

¹⁴ Jean Blondel, "Political Science," in Adam Kuper and Jessica Kuper, eds., *The Social Science Encyclopedia* (London: Routledge & Kegan Paul, 1985), p. 617.

¹⁵ Woodward, "Public Opinion Polls," p. 239.

¹⁶ "Polls, Propaganda, and Democracy," p. 1.

¹⁷ Dongbei renmin zhengfu gonganbu, "Guanyu jiaqiang zhencha gongzuo de zhishi" (Instructions on Strengthening Operational Work), *Gongan baowei gongzuo* (Public Security and Protection Work), No. 17, February 15, 1950, p. 25. The now archaic *sheqing* was an abbreviation of *shehui qingbao*. A rare example of use of the full unabbreviated term occurs in Li Kenong, "Zhi Bu Shengguang" (Letter to Bu Shengguang) [18 March 1950], in *Li Kenong jinian wenji* (Collected Writings in Memory of Li Kenong) (Beijing, 2000), p. 248. Today, *sheqing* is commonly used as the abbreviation of *shehui qingkuang*, meaning "social situation" or "community circumstances."

¹⁸ Dongbei renmin zhengfu gonganbu, "Guanyu jiaqiang zhencha gongzuo," p. 25.

¹⁹ Zhonggong Huabei shehuibu, "Jiaqiang sheqing gongzuo de yijian" (Opinion on Strengthening Social Intelligence Work) [22 October 1951].

²⁰ Ibid.

²¹ Ibid.; "Ruhe shouji sheqing."

²² Zhonghua renmin gongheguo gonganbu, "Guanyu gongan xitong gexiang baogao zhidu de xiuding guiding" (Revised Rules to Govern the Reports System in the Public Security Sector) (January 1955), *Gongan jianshe* (Public Security Construction), No. 118 (7 March 1955), p. 26.

²³ Bureau of Social Affairs of the City Government of Greater Shanghai, *Standard of Living of Shanghai Laborers* (Shanghai: Zhonghua shuju, 1934), pp. 85–89.

²⁴ Tong Lam, *A Passion for Facts* (Berkeley: University of California Press, 2011), p. 90.

²⁵ Li Kenong, "Zhi Bu Shengguang," p. 248.

²⁶ Riesman and Glazer, "The Meaning of Opinion," p. 634, 642.

²⁷ Compare "Polls, Propaganda, and Democracy," p. 5.

²⁸ "Ruhe shouji sheqing."

²⁹ Hadley Cantril, *The Human Dimension: Experiences in Policy Research* (New Brunswick: Rutgers University Press, 1967), pp. 99–102.

³⁰ Howard Becker, "The Nature and Consequences of Black Propaganda," *American Sociological Review*, Vol. 14, No. 2 (April 1949), pp. 226–227.

³¹ Zhang Shijing, "Tehu de diaocha dengji wenti" (Problems of Investigating and Registering Special Households), *Renmin gongan zengkan*, No. 9 (25 June 1950), pp. 40–46. On the Public Security School, see Mu Yumin, *Beijing jingcha bainian* (One Hundred Years of the Beijing Police) (Beijing: Zhongguo renmin gongan daxue chubanshe, 2004), pp. 411–412.

³² "Teqing koutou baogao jilu" (Agent Debriefing Record) (15 July 1963), in *502 hao teqing gongzuo anjuan* (Work File of Agent 502). In my possession is only the folder (160 pages, no pagination, but seemingly complete) from this agent work file that covers the period from June 1963 through February 1966. I obtained the folder in a Beijing flea market in 2013.

³³ Huabei shehuibu, "Sige yue lai zhixing qingkuang zonghe baogao" (Summary Report on [Social Intelligence] Implementation over the Past Four Months) [22 October 1951] p. 3.

³⁴ Zhonggong Tianjin shiwei, "Guanyu tongyi Jin shi sheqing gongzuo fang'an" (Plan for the Consolidation of Social Intelligence Work in Tianjin Municipality) [18 June 1951].

³⁵ Compare Martin Stief, "Die ZAIG – Nachrichten-zentrale der Stasi," in Daniela Münkel, Ronny Heidenreich and Martin Stief, eds., *Geheimdienste, Politik und Krisen im Kalten Krieg* (Göttingen: Vandenhoeck & Ruprecht, 2025), p. 80.

³⁶ Shaanxi sheng gonganting, "Guanyu zhengdun sheqing gongzuo de baogao" (Report on Strengthening Social Intelligence Work) [16 December 1952].

³⁷ "Guanyu fashe daodan he wuqi zhigong fanying zhi yi" (No. 1 Opinions of [Railway] Workers and Staff on the Launch of a Nuclear Warhead Missile), *Beijing gongan fenchu qingkuang jianbao* (Beijing Public Security Sub-Division Situation Bulletin), No. 85, 9 November 1966.

³⁸ Zhonggong Huabeiju shehuibu, "Jiaqiang sheqing gongzuo."

³⁹ Zhonggong Tianjin shiwei, "Guanyu tongyi Jin shi sheqing" and Zhonggong Huabeiju shehuibu, "Jiaqiang sheqing gongzuo."

⁴⁰ Arthur N. Feraru, "Public Opinion Polls on China," *Far Eastern Survey*, Vol. 19, No. 13 (12 July 1950), p. 131.

⁴¹ From February to June 1977, I was one of three political science graduates employed by the Swedish Institute of International Affairs to code a massive corpus of statements by Chinese, U.S., and Soviet officials for a project intended to quantify Cold War international tension over time. The project rested on altogether false assumptions, but generated an impressive volume of numbers, tables, and charts.

⁴² Cantril, *The Pattern*, pp. 342–344.

⁴³ "Ji'nan de qunzhong he zichanjieji fenzi dui teshe shoupi zhanfan de fanying" (Stated Opinions of the Masses and of Bourgeois Elements in Ji'nan on First Batch of Amnestied War Criminals) and "Beijing gejie dui teshe shoupi zhanfan he zhaidiao yipi youpai maozi de fanying" (Stated Opinions of Various Strata in Beijing on First Batches of Amnestied War Criminals and De-Labelled Rightists), *Gongan gongzuo jianbao* (Public Security Work Bulletin), No. 82 (6 December 1959), p. 9–10, 6–7.

⁴⁴ "Jiben qunzhong dui teshe shoupi zhanfan de fanying" (Stated Opinions of the Basic Masses on First Batch of Amnestied War Criminals), *Gongan gongzuo jianbao*, No. 83 (14 December 1959), p. 6.

⁴⁵ Zhonghua renmin gongheguo gonganbu, "Guanyu gongan xitong gexiang baogao zhidu de xiuding guiding."

⁴⁶ Hu Qiaomu, "Zai gongan gongzuo shang zenyang ba gongkai de wenzi xuanchuan zuode geng hao yixie?" (26 September 1955), p. 16.

⁴⁷ Hu Qiaomu, "Zai xie wenjian fangfa zuotanhui shang de jianghua" (4 March 1958), p. 14.

⁴⁸ Ibid.

⁴⁹ Ibid.

⁵⁰ Gonganbu dangzu, "Guanyu gaijin gongan bumen baogao zhidu de guiding" (7 July 1960), *Gongan jianshe*, No. 56, 1960.

⁵¹ Converse, *Survey Research in the United States*, p. 98.

⁵² Shenyang gaoya kaiguanchang baoweike, "Guanyu gaijin sheqing gongzuo" (On Improving Social Intelligence Work) [13 July 1954].

⁵³ *Wang Huacheng huiyi* (Wang Huacheng Remembers) (Harbin: Zhonggong Harbin shiwei dangshi yanjiushi, 2004), p. 80, 99.

⁵⁴ What follows draws on the surviving file of Agent 107 (approx. 230 pages with page numbers stamped on them) covering a period from May 1950 to April 1951. I obtained it in a Beijing flea market in 2013.

⁵⁵ "Shouwen Chen zi di 3 hao" (Incoming No. 3 from Chen) (27 May 1950), in *107 hao teqing gongzuo anjuan* (Work File of Agent 107), p. 114.

⁵⁶ "Zhe ci fanying de qingkuang" (Circumstances Reported on this Occasion) (12 April 1951), in *107 hao teqing gongzuo anjuan*, p. 79.

⁵⁷ Ibid., p. 82.

⁵⁸ Ibid., p. 84.

⁵⁹ "Sanyuefen pohuai shijian jianbao" (Bulletin on Instances of Sabotage in the Month of March) [14 April 1951], *Renmin gongan zengkan*, Vol. 2, No. 5 (15 May 1951), pp. 62–63.

⁶⁰ See Zhang Xinyi and Cheng Tingkui, "Zai teqing gongzuo shang guanche shousuo fangzhen de jidian tihui" (Some Findings from Implementation of Downsizing and Rectification), *Neimeng gongan* (Inner Mongolia Public Security), No. 56 (1957), pp. 37–41.

⁶¹ Woodward, "Public Opinion Polls," p. 244. Robert K. Merton, *Social Theory and Social Structure* (1957), cited in Everett M. Rogers and David G. Cartano, "Methods of Measuring Opinion Leadership," *The Public Opinion Quarterly*, Vol. 26, No. 3 (Autumn 1962), p. 436.

⁶² What follows draws on the surviving file of Agent 371. In my possession is only the folder (approx. 200 pages, no pagination) from the work file covering the period from July 1955 to August 1957. I obtained the folder in a Beijing flea market in 2013.

⁶³ See "Zhongyang guanyu jinyibu kaizhan zhiyuan Aiji fankang qinlüe douzheng de tongzhi" (Central Notification on Further Aiding Egypt in Resisting a War of Aggression) (15 November 1956) and "Zhonggong zhongyang guanyu 1957 nian xinnian qijian xuanchuan gongzuo de tongzhi" (Notification of the CCP Centre on Propaganda Work during the 1957 New Year) (27 December 1956), in *Zhongguo gongchandang xuanchuan gongzuo wenxian xuanbian* (Selected CCP Historical Records on Propaganda Work), 4 vols. (Beijing: Xuexi chubanshe, 1996), Vol. 3, pp. 1192–93, 1201–1202.

⁶⁴ "Dui Jin shi fuzi jinyibu de fenxi" (Analysis in Greater Depth of Relations Between Jin Father and Son) (20 August 1955) in *371 hao teqing gongzuo anjuan* (Work File of Agent 371).

⁶⁵ "Beijing Shanghai dengdi dui Xizang panluan shijian de fanying," *Gongan gongzuo jianbao*, No. 36 (3 April 1959), p. 4.

⁶⁶ "Jin Zhensheng" (Jin Zhensheng) (21 March 1956), in *371 hao teqing gongzuo anjuan*.

⁶⁷ "Guanyu daming dafang de yixie cailiao" (Some Information on Great Blooming and Great Contending) (15 June 1957), in *371 hao teqing gongzuo anjuan*.

⁶⁸ "Dongtai jilei biao" (Accumulated Trends Form) (28 December 1956), in *371 hao teqing gongzuo anjuan*.

⁶⁹ "Jin Shaochen" (Jin Shaochen) (2 February 1957), in *371 hao teqing gongzuo anjuan*.

⁷⁰ "Guanyu Fuluoxiluofu zhuxi lai Zhongguo fangwen dedao de fanying" (Stated Opinions Picked Up Concerning President Voroshilov's Visit to China) (5 May 1957), in *371 hao teqing gongzuo anjuan*.

⁷¹ "Jiangxi xueshuji taolun xin zichanjieji fenzi wenti" (Academic Circles in Jiangxi Debate the New Bourgeois Elements Issue), *Xuanjiao dongtai* (Trends in Propaganda and Education), No. 3, 1964, pp. 4–9.

⁷² Xu Chongde, "Wuchanjieji tong zichanjieji fenzi jian de maodun shuyu shenme xingzhi" (What is the Nature of Contradictions Between the Proletariat and Bourgeois Elements), *Weiding wengao* (Preliminary Article Drafts), No. 3, 1964, pp. 39–40.

⁷³ See Zhonggong zhongyang zuzhibu bangongting, ed. *Zuzhi gongzuo wenjian xuanbian 1953 nian–1954 nian* (Selected Organization Work Documents: 1953–1954) (Beijing: Zhonggong zhongyang zuzhibu bangongting, 1980), p. 175.

⁷⁴ "In Refutation of 'Uniformity of Public Opinion'" (24 May 1955), in *Selected Works of Mao Zedong* (Beijing: Foreign Languages Press, 1977), Vol. 5, pp. 172–174.

⁷⁵ "Things are Beginning to Change" (15 May 1957), in *Selected Works of Mao Zedong*, Vol. 5, p. 443.

⁷⁶ See *Jianguo yilai Mao Zedong wengao* (Mao Zedong's Manuscripts Since the Founding of the Nation) 13 vols. (Beijing: Zhongyang wenxian chubanshe, 1996), Vol. 10, p. 194.

⁷⁷ *151 hao teqing geren anjuan* (Personal File of Agent 151). In my possession are only some (approx. 300 pages, incompletely paginated) of the folders from this agent personal file covering a period from 1950 through 1963. I obtained the folder in a Beijing flea market in the winter of 2012.

⁷⁸ "San nian guihua" (Three Year Plan) (10 May 1964), in *594 hao teqing gongzuo anjuan* (Work File of Agent 594). In my possession is only the folder (approx. 130 pages, no pagination) from this agent work file that covers the period from March 1964 to October 1966. I obtained the folder in a Beijing flea market in 2013.

⁷⁹ "502 hao teqing gongzuo anjuan."

⁸⁰ "Teqing koutou baogao jilu" (23 April 1964), in *594 hao teqing gongzuo anjuan*.

⁸¹ "Teqing koutou baogao jilu" (6 August 1963), in *502 hao teqing gongzuo anjuan*.

⁸² "Teqing koutou baogao jilu" (9 September 1963), in *502 hao teqing gongzuo anjuan*.

⁸³ Schoenhals, *Spying for the People*, pp. 99–100.

⁸⁴ Mao Zedong, "Yao rang renmin zhidao di xiu fan zai gao xie shenme" (We should let the people know what the imperialists, revisionists, and reactionaries are up to), in *Mao zhuxi Lin fuzhuxi guanyu baokan xuanchuan de zhishi* (Chairman Mao's and Vice-Chairman Lin's instructions on press and propaganda work) (N.p., 1970), p. 281.

⁸⁵ "Xinhua tongxun she guanyu *Cankao xiaoxi* gaiban kuoda faxing hou bianji fangzhen de yijian" (Views of the Xinhua News Agency on the Editorial Policy of *Reference News* Subsequent to its Altered Format and Wider Distribution) (9 February 1957), in *Zhongguo gongchandang xuanchuan gongzuo wenxian xuanbian*, Vol. 4, p. 18.

⁸⁶ Li Ke, untitled 5-page memorandum (16 January 1962), in *151 hao teqing geren anjuan*.

⁸⁷ “Teqing koutou baogao jilu” (Agent Debriefing Record) (5 November 1965), in *502 hao teqing gongzuo anjuan*.

⁸⁸ Ibid.

⁸⁹ “Sheqing diaocha gongzuo” (Social Intelligence Investigation Work), in Tianjin tielu guanliju gonganchu, ed., *Gongan yewu xuexi cailiao* (Public Security Vocational Study Material) (Tianjin, 20 June 1952), p. 6.

⁹⁰ “Teqing koutou baogao jilu” (Agent Debriefing Record) (24 December 1965), in *502 hao teqing gongzuo anjuan*.

⁹¹ “Teqing koutou baogao jilu” (Agent Debriefing Record) (27 February 1966), in *502 hao teqing gongzuo anjuan*.

⁹² “Teqing koutou baogao jilu” (Agent Debriefing Record) (2 June 1966), in *594 hao teqing gongzuo anjuan*.

⁹³ “Teqing koutou baogao jilu” (Agent Debriefing Record) (8 September 1966), in *594 hao teqing gongzuo anjuan*.

⁹⁴ “Guanyu fashe daodan he wuqi zhigong fanying zhi yi.”

⁹⁵ Michael Schoenhals, “China’s ‘Great Proletarian Information Revolution’ of 1966–1967,” in Jeremy Brown and Matthew D. Johnson, eds., *Maoism at the Grassroots: Everyday Life in China’s Era of High Socialism* (Cambridge MA: Harvard University Press, 2015), pp. 230–258.